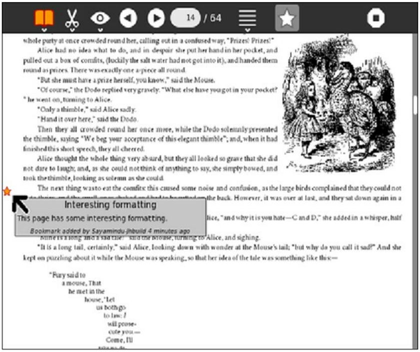

The OLPC XO eBookReader

do), but here's what I think.

I firmly believe that kids can create their own content (if this sounds odd, take a look at *http://scratch.mit.edu*). However, books have been, and will be a major source of knowledge, ideas, and inspiration for generations to come (if not paper books, definitely, e-books). I tend to look back at my own childhood where books were the primary drivers of my curiosity (and perhaps the general direction my life has taken). Had it not been for that interesting book with a funny picture of a penguin on it, the one that I bought at the Calcutta Book Fair, I would probably be trying to finish my masters in Physics or English now.

When I hear of stories of people like William Kamkwamba -- a young man in Africa, with almost no education, who saw a picture of a windmill in a library book and decided to build one for his village -- my ideas about the immense potential of books to inspire are reinforced. Now imagine what could happen in a country like Uruguay, where 400,000 kids have laptops of their own, if each laptop is loaded with a hundred books (a typical EPUB book is usually not larger than a megabyte).

Read activity (as well as Read Etexts activity—which is another great book reader by Jim Simmons) has support for sharing books. This means that if a child decides to share her book, everyone in the neighbourhood can get a copy (and not a copy that will self-destruct after 14 days). You have an effective distribution of 400,000x100 books in a country, all of them for kids!

Another interesting thing about reading books on the OLPC is the hardware. Most mainstream e-book-readers nowadays come with e-ink displays, which are extremely power-efficient, but do not support colour, and can be quite sluggish (though apparently, one can improve that). OLPC's dual mode display takes the middle path—when you go out in the sunlight to read, you turn the screen into 'reflective mode' where the screen's backlight gets turned off, and you can read in the sunlight. And when you are indoors, or need to see some colours, you just turn the backlight back on.

Q How does the software source books?

This is another part of my current efforts. Jim Simmons had originally built an Activity called Get Internet Archive Books, which queried the Internet Archive (IA) and let users download individual books into the Sugar Journal. At the same time, OLPC had been participating in the drafting process of the OPDS (Open Publication Distribution System) standard, which is an XML (more specifically, Atom) based catalogue format targeted at book-publishers and distributors. OPDS servers usually also support a standardised method for searching through the catalogues, and so I extended Jim's 'Get Internet Archive Books' activity to work with OPDS (it had to be renamed to the 'Get Books' activity, since it was no longer restricted to material from the IA).

We were one of the first to implement a client side tool for OPDS, and currently Get Books can query the Internet Archive's BookServer (which is also a very interesting project) at *www.archive.org/bookserver* and *Feedbooks.com*. (Incidentally, the Internet Archive alone has more than 1.5 million books.)

Q There aren't enough textbooks available that can make the eBookReader relevant. What do you think needs to be done?

Oh, there are quite a few interesting initiatives (and some of them are showing very promising real results as well). Some of them include CK-12 (ck12.org), Replacing Textbooks from the Earth Treasury (*www.earthtreasury.org/wiki.cgi?ReplacingTextbooks*), wikibooks (*en.wikibooks.org/wiki/Main_Page*), the work going on at OLE Nepal, etc. I'm sure to have missed out a huge number of projects—apologies to all of them. The work done by FLOSSManuals (*en.flossmanuals.net*) may be quite relevant as well. Local language, non-English e-text-books, are however more difficult to find.